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‘One country, two narratives’ of China as a nation: comparing Chinese history education in mainland China and Hong Kong

Shuqin Xu 

Research Center for Public Administration and School of Government, Sun Yat-Sen University, Guangzhou, People’s Republic of China

ABSTRACT

This study explores the narration of China as a nation in history education in two regions – mainland China and Hong Kong – that share cultural roots but different socio-political contexts. Inductive analysis of data from junior-secondary Chinese history textbooks used in the regions in the late 2010s revealed that whereas mainland China’s textbooks constructed China as a nation by stressing its constitutive territory and ethnic inclusiveness, Hong Kong’s highlighted its constitutive ethnicity and changing territory, more frequently and directly narrated interethnic conflicts, and more explicitly promoted Han superiority. The study proposes constructing the nation in history education as a contextualised and socio-political exercise of reinterpreting the past to reflect current contexts and needs.

KEYWORDS

Nation; history education; history textbooks; China; Hong Kong

关键词

国家; 历史教育; 历史教科书; 中国; 香港

‘一个国家，两种叙事’：对中国大陆和香港历史教育中国家叙事的比较

摘要

本研究探讨中国大陆和香港这两个地区历史教育中关于中国作为一个国家的叙事，这两个地区有共同的文化根源，但社会政治背景并不相同。通过对2010年代末两地使用的初中中国历史教科书数据进行归纳分析，发现中国大陆的教科书通过强调中国的领土构成和民族包容性来建构中国的国家叙事，而香港的教科书则强调中国的民族构成和领土变化，且更频繁和直接地讲述民族冲突，并更明确地宣扬汉族的优越性。本研究建议将历史教育中的国家建构视为一种重新阐释过去以反映当前背景和需求的情境化的社会政治活动。

Introduction

Comparative education explores how school education shapes historical memory and narrates the nation with which students identify, an issue more complex in modern states with multi-ethnic/race populations or centre-periphery tensions (e.g. Latif 2019; Takeda and Williams 2008; Won and Huntington 2021). While some states (e.g. Canada) pursue national cohesion through inclusive education (Takeda and Williams 2008), other education systems highlight the dominant groups’ knowledge and views, often

CONTACT Shuqin Xu ✉ xushuqin3@mail.sysu.edu.cn  Research Center for Public Administration and School of Government, Sun Yat-Sen University, Guangzhou, People’s Republic of China

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in biased ways unconvincing and unacceptable to minority students (Williams and Bokhorst-Heng 2016). National history has wrought more debates and conflicts than other school curricula (Williams and Bokhorst-Heng 2016). History textbooks in states with a shared ethnicity (e.g. South Korea and North Korea) (Won and Huntington 2021) or multi-ethnic countries (Takeda and Williams 2008) can narrate a nation differently.

The complexity of narrating the nation is particularly obvious in the People's Republic of China (PRC), with its ethnic and centre-periphery issues. China has 56 official ethnic groups, including the Han (91.1%) and 55 ethnic minority groups (8.89%) that mainly inhabit China's border regions. In constructing the nation, dealing with Han and non-Han ethnicities is an important policy and academic concern (e.g. Leibold and Dorjee 2024; Yan and Vickers 2019; 2024). Moreover, the 'one country, two systems' framework implemented in Hong Kong, a British colony from 1840 and China's first special administrative region after its 1997 return, is arguably a centre-periphery governance model in which the PRC's central government (the centre) has sovereignty over Hong Kong (the periphery). However, the 'one country, two systems' framework officially permits Hong Kong to maintain its capitalist system and way of life, affording it significant, if incomplete, autonomy (except in foreign affairs and national defence) under Chinese rule for 50 years. Various tensions exist between mainland China and Hong Kong (Vickers and Morris 2022), though the central and Hong Kong governments seek to foster a new national identity among Hong Kong students through education, especially Chinese history education (Kan 2007; Vickers 2024).

Many educational studies have highlighted how mainland China and Hong Kong employ Chinese history education differently to foster students' national identity. The literature revealed that mainland Chinese history curricula narrate China as a unified multi-ethnic nation, while Hong Kong's depict it as a Han-centric ethnocultural nation (e.g. Kan 2007; Lin and Jackson 2019; Lo 2004; 2007; Yan and Vickers 2019; 2024). While helping explain the complexity of national identity cultivation through education, these studies could be advanced in two ways. First, few studies compare Chinese history curricula in mainland China and Hong Kong, and those of Lo (2004; 2007) are dated and insufficient for comparing the Chinese history education issues emerging as the regions are increasingly integrated (Morris and Vickers 2015; Vickers 2024). Second, most studies focus on ethnic issues, especially marginalised ethnic minorities' representation in Chinese history textbooks, downplaying the territorial issues the Communist Party of China (CPC) emphasises in its national narration. Baranovitch (2010) notes that the unified multi-ethnic nation view depicts China as a territorial nation and bases its national boundaries on physical territory, while the ethnocultural view bases them on Han ethnicity.

Following Lu's (2017) framework for distinguishing between ethnocultural and territorial notions of China, this study compares how mainland China and Hong Kong junior-secondary Chinese history textbooks narrate China as a nation via two research questions: (1) What are the two narratives' similarities and differences? (2) Why are they presented as they are?

Perspectives on the nation

Nations are conceptualised from different perspectives, falling along a primordial-modern spectrum (Ozкимli 2010). The spectrum's primordial end sees a nation as a given, natural,

eternal, ancestral, and immemorial community (Ozkirimli 2010) connected by ethnocultural ties (e.g. language, blood, religion, custom, territory) (e.g. Connor 1978; Shils 1957). For example, Smith (1991) conceptualised a nation as 'a named human population sharing a historic territory, common myths and historical memories, a mass, public culture, a common economy and common legal rights and duties of all members' (14). The primordial perspective, however, has been criticised for overemphasising ethnicity and insufficiently explaining how modern states with diverse ethnocultural groups (e.g. ethnic minorities, immigrants, indigenous people) foster national identity (Guibernau 2004).

The spectrum's modern end sees a nation as an artificial, novel, political product of modernisation since the late eighteenth century (Ozkirimli 2010). Anderson (2006) defined a nation as an 'imagined political community' having comradeship, a finite boundary, and sovereignty; it is imagined because 'the members of even the smallest nation will never know most of their fellow members, meet them, or even hear of them, yet in the minds of each lives the image of their communion' (6). This imagined community is facilitated by, for example, education (Gellner 1983) and print capitalism creating a shared culture and language and simplifying communication (Anderson 2006). However, modern perspective advocates have been criticised for (1) turning the nation into an artificial universal construction by delinking it from its historical roots and (2) neglecting power relations and socio-political contexts (Ozkirimli 2010).

Several intermediate perspectives lie between these two extremes. One is ethno-symbolism, which, rather than depicting the nation as either 'natural' (as primordialists assume) or artificial (as modernists claim), combines ethnicity with modern view to reinterpret pre-modern ethnic symbols, myths, memories, and traditions (Smith 1998), politically manipulating the nation's culture (Guibernau 2004). Another intermediate perspective notes that some nations stress ethnocultural elements (e.g. shared culture, language, ancestry) and other civic elements (e.g. shared political ideology, rights, institutions) (e.g. Brubaker 1992; Tamir 2019). For example, Germany's and France's nation-construction goals produced different ethnic/civic positionings (Brubaker 1992). Germany, focusing on cultural unity, considers ethnicity/ethnic culture constitutive (e.g. pre-existing and historically consistent) and territory expressive (e.g. dynamic and changeable), while France, prioritising political unity, deems territory constitutive and ethnicity expressive (i.e. shows ethnic inclusivity). Brubaker (1996) further pointed out that a nation is not established (as primordialism, modernism, and ethno-symbolism assume) but developed through the dynamic manipulation of nation-related concepts (e.g. ethnicity, territory) in different socio-political contexts.

Constructing the nation in history education and textbooks

Brubaker's (1996) developmental argument on nation construction is reflected in history curricula and textbooks that are critical for disseminating 'official knowledge' and constructing a nation with distinct features (Williams and Bokhorst-Heng 2016). By reinterpreting selected myths, traditions, symbols, and memories, history curricula could shape students' understandings and collective memory of the past to reflect then-dominant groups' interests (Apple and Christian-Smith 1991; Williams and Bokhorst-Heng 2016). In different states/societies (or a single country's different periods), history curricula

and textbooks could narrate a nation differently, reflecting then-current socio-political contexts (Klerides 2009; Latif 2019; Won and Huntington 2021). Differences in national narration could reflect political elites' legitimisation strategies (Latif 2019) and textbook authors' different aims/resources for teaching the state's past (Klerides 2009).

Brubaker's (1992, 1996) perspective on national construction can be found in China's history curricula. Lu (2017) revealed that mainland China's history curricula have reinterpreted constitutive ethnocultural and constitutive territorial notions since 1955, reflecting the two camps' views of China as a nation. The ethnocultural notion contends that China is defined by and has primordality in Han ethnicity and culture, which originated in the Central Plains (*zhongyuan*), developed and expanded by absorbing other cultural elements (e.g. Hsu 2012). China's territory comprised areas accepting Han culture and various Central Plain rulers' governance, and it was changeable, as not all ethnicities continually accepted the Han (Hsu 2012). The territorial notion (e.g. Fei 1999) argues that China is delimited by and has primordality in its contemporary territory, which can be traced to antiquity, and that the 56 ethnicities historically residing within that territory create a unified multi-ethnic Chinese nation (*zhonghua minzu*). All 56 ethnic groups jointly created Chinese history and shared the mainstream culture while keeping their own (Fei 1999). Lu (2017) suggested six factors to distinguish ethnocultural and territorial notions of China: (1) ethnic definitions, (2) territorial definitions, (3) governance in peripheral areas, (4) interethnic warfare, (5) interethnic relations, and (6) ethnicities' cultural statuses.

The socio-political contexts of history education in mainland China and Hong Kong

Since 1840, mainland China and Hong Kong have experienced different histories, different nation constructions, and changing patterns of constructed nation promotion in their history curricula and textbooks.

Mainland China

From the nineteenth to mid-twentieth centuries, China faced frequent invasions and civil wars, shattering its Sinocentric worldview – China as the Middle Kingdom, above the Earth but below Heaven – and driving the Republic of China (1912–1949) and PRC (1949–) leaders to reconstruct their notions of China to pursue their political agendas. In the 1950s, to maintain territorial integrity and social stability (Law 2017), the CPC began promoting China as a unified multi-ethnic nation under CPC leadership comprising 56 inseparable ethnicities sharing a single national identity and territory (Fei 1999). Moreover, since the 1980s, the CPC has gradually fostered national identity with traditional Chinese culture which the Party had previously denounced as a shackle on China's effort at modernisation (Xu 2018).

The Ministry of Education of China has administered curricula and textbooks (including for Chinese history) to promote the CPC's political prescriptions, including China as a unified multi-ethnic nation, in different political contexts (Xu 2021a). From the late 1980s to 2017, to cultivate students for China's competition with other nations, improve textbook quality, and address local diversity, the Ministry of Education gradually

decentralised textbook writing and publishing to local publishers, subject to national curriculum standards and Ministry review (Law 2014). Since 2017 and per Xi Jinping's 'textbooks as a state affair' instructions, the Ministry has mandated that all national junior secondary Chinese language, politics, and history textbooks must be written by Ministry-selected writing committees, reviewed by the National Textbook Committee, and published by the People's Education Press (Xu 2021b).

Despite these changes, mainland Chinese history curricula and textbooks have consistently legitimised the present with the past (Xu 2021a) and (since the 1950s) promoted the territorial notion of China as a unified multi-ethnic nation (Lu 2017) to prevent interethnic conflicts, particularly those inspired by non-Han extremists and separatists (Law 2017). However, despite their territorial focus, mainland Chinese history textbooks have grown more Han-centric since the 1990s (Yan and Vickers 2024; 2019). To legitimise the CPC-prescribed Han-centric multi-ethnic nation perspective, the Ministry of Education recruited historians as Chinese history textbook editors but strictly censored their political backgrounds (Xu 2021b). For example, Qu Lindong was named as a junior secondary Chinese history textbook editor because his publications echoed the CPC-prescribed vision of China as a Han-centric multi-ethnic nation (Yan and Vickers 2024). His articles avoided inter-ethnic conflicts and highlighted non-Han minorities' significance and contributions throughout China's history, while maintaining Han cultural, economic, and policy superiority (Yan and Vickers 2024).

Hong Kong

While mainland Chinese elites have promoted the nation as a political community, Hongkongers' views have varied with local and Chinese governance. Before the Second World War, most identified as mainland Chinese refugees expecting to return to China; however, local identification developed as Hongkongers, especially mainland refugees, became settled following the 1950s introduction of immigration restrictions (Luk 1991). Hongkongers' local identity was enhanced by better living standards, greater cultural diversity, more liberal institutions, and education that promoted liberal values such as the rule of law but prevented their identification with contemporary China (Kan 2007).

Before 1997, Hong Kong's Chinese history curricula/textbooks echoed its political climate and governance and differed from mainland China's in two aspects. First, the British government decentralised Chinese-language history textbook writing and publication, allowing textbooks based on locally developed official curriculum guides to be reviewed before being recommended to schools (Kan 2007).

Moreover, Hong Kong's Chinese history curriculum/textbooks promoted China as a Han-centric ethnocultural nation to foster students' identification with China's cultural heritage rather than contemporary regimes (Kan and Vickers 2002). This could be seen as a 'collaborative contract' between British administrators and local Chinese cultural conservationists who drafted the original textbooks and curriculum policies (Kan and Vickers 2002). The latter included conservative intellectuals who fled the PRC in the late 1940s and 1950s, notably historian Qian Mu, who was influential in preserving and promoting Chinese culture and shaping the philosophy of Chinese history education in Hong Kong as a British colony (and Taiwan) (Au 2018). Rather than viewing traditional Chinese culture as contributing to China's backwardness as the CPC did before the

1980s, Qian contended it was ‘the source of Chinese identity and the key to [China’s] national revival’ (Vickers, Kan, and Morris 2003, 101) and promoted Confucian values (Soffel 2013).

Since the cultural conservationists’ views suited the colonial agenda of maintaining the Crown’s political domination and avoiding the spread of revolutionary fervour, they were adopted in the then-Chinese history curricula and textbooks (Vickers, Kan, and Morris 2003). As a result, these curriculum resources narrated China as a nation and Chinese history from culturally conservative and Han-chauvinist perspectives based on uniquely Chinese cultural elements, highlighting the Han’s cultural superiority, civilisation, and moral values while disparaging non-Han but excluding contemporary accounts of foreign encroachments on Chinese sovereignty (in which Britain had participated) and the CPC’s leadership (Luk 1991).

After its 1997 retrocession, the Hong Kong government exercised its autonomy over local education to reform its Chinese history curricula and increase students’ sense of being Chinese and ‘belonging to China and the Chinese race’ (Curriculum Development Council 1997, 8) while still decentralising Chinese history textbook writing and publication and perpetuating a Han-centric ethnocultural notion of China. Despite including coverage of contemporary China, the post-1997 Chinese history curriculum emphasised the remote past, the development of Han-centric China, and the inclusiveness and innovativeness of Chinese culture (Lo 2007). This curriculum reflected new government and curriculum developer concerns. Unlike the British administrators, the Hong Kong government used the Han-centric ethnocultural China notion to accommodate local diversity and internationalisation (Lo 2007). Many Chinese history subject committee members and textbook writers had been trained and influenced by cultural conservationists like Qian Mu and were less loyal to the state *per se* than to a sense of national identity broadly based on Chinese culture and values (Kan 2007).

Despite the ‘one country, two systems’ framework, Hong Kong has witnessed increased CPC-led central government involvement and intensified centre-local tensions following the 2012 anti-national education movement, the 2014 Umbrella Movement, and the 2019 Anti-Extradition Law Amendment Bill Movement (Vickers and Morris 2022). After 2012, China’s central government pressed Hong Kong to reform its Chinese history curriculum (Morris and Vickers 2015), review and fine-tune Chinese history textbooks in 2013, decouple it from other subjects from September 2018, publish a new curriculum guide in 2019, and implement it in phases from September 2020. Key changes in the 2019 Chinese history curriculum guide focus on fostering students’ ‘sense of state and national identification, belonging, and responsibility’, emphasising contemporary Chinese history and highlighting Hong Kong as a Chinese territory from antiquity (Curriculum Development Council 2020, 5).

However, constructing China as a nation in Hong Kong’s Chinese history curriculum faces two tensions. The first is Hong Kong’s diverse population; over 90% of Hongkongers are Han Chinese migrants/descendants from mainland China, while the remainder are non-Chinese migrants/descendants from various countries. The latter find learning Chinese history difficult, as it is taught in Chinese. The second concerns how to narrate/promote China to Hongkongers who hold conflicting PRC and Hong Kong Special Administrative Region citizenship identities – with the former recently decreasing

among Hong Kong youths (Vickers 2024), especially after the promulgation of the *National Security Law for Hong Kong* in 2020.

Data and analysis

This study drew data from two sets of junior-secondary history textbooks for Grades 7–9 – ‘Chinese History’ textbooks (volumes 1–3) in mainland China (mainland China textbooks, hereafter) and ‘New Brief Chinese History’ (volumes 1–3) in Hong Kong (Hong Kong textbooks hereafter) – for three reasons. First, the textbooks promote Chinese history education’s national and local agendas. The mainland set was written and published under the Ministry of Education’s administration and adopted in mainland junior-secondary schools. The Hong Kong set was published by Ling Kee Publishing Group. Other Hong Kong publishers’ textbooks followed the same official curriculum guides and shared similar learning goals, structure, and contents, reflecting the local authority’s identity construction (Lin and Jackson 2019).

Second, both textbook sets followed curriculum guides predating Xi Jinping’s 2012 ascension. The mainland set, published between 2016 and 2017, followed the Ministry of Education’s 2011 junior-secondary history curriculum standard (fine-tuned from 2001). The Hong Kong set, published in 2014, followed the 1997 Chinese history curriculum. Both sets were used in schools in the late 2010s and 2020. Although Hong Kong revised its Chinese history curriculum in 2019 and began to phase in new textbooks from Grade 7 in 2020, mainland China has yet to publish new Chinese history textbooks that reflect its 2022 curriculum. For the sake of comparison on a similar footing, this study decided to analyse the textbooks each region used in 2020.

Third, both textbook sets were comparable, mainly narrating China as a nation chronologically through main texts, supplementary readings, exercises, and maps. The study specifically focuses on narratives of China as a nation before 1912, when China’s dynasticism ended and a modern nation emerged. Pre- and post-1912 Chinese nationhood were treated differently in both textbook sets and merit separate studies.

The author analysed the textbooks using a qualitative inductive approach, i.e. deriving themes and models by reading, categorising, and interpreting the raw data (Corbin and Strauss 2015) in three steps. First, the author, a native Chinese, read all versions of mainland China and Hong Kong history textbooks to ascertain how they narrated China as a nation, copied all relevant main texts into an Excel spreadsheet, and then divided them into clauses for further analysis. A clause employs a subject and verb to describe an issue/event; it may have different data points (Cambridge Dictionary 2008). For example, the clause, ‘He highly valued Han officials, reformed political institutions, rewarded agriculture’, has three data points. A clause is more meaningful and appropriate than other units (e.g. sentence, paragraph, page size/quantity) for this analysis. Second, the author coded the excerpted main texts using codes that emerged after initial analysis, informed by the narratives’ ethnocultural and territorial patterns. Some resembled Lu’s (2017) indicators (e.g. ‘non-Han military’s atrocity’); those that differed (e.g. ‘taking back central plains’) were used to modify them. These codes were then used to compare and analyse supplementary readings, figures, and maps. Several categories emerged, including ‘Han-centric China’ and ‘multi-ethnic nation’. Third, the author generated

narrative themes by examining and comparing the categories in both regions' textbooks, finding four themes (see 'Findings' section).

A native Chinese-speaking colleague helped triangulate the data by dividing the textbooks' clauses and coding their excerpts. The author and colleague re-examined and discussed any divergent divisions and codes until an agreement was reached. Textbook quotations were coded to indicate their version, volume, and page; e.g. 'mainland China-2, 66' identifies information cited from page 66 of Volume 2 of the mainland Chinese textbooks.

'One country, two narratives' of Chinese nationhood

Based on Lu's (2017) analysis of the 'nation' construct, this study found that mainland China and Hong Kong Chinese textbooks exhibited a 'one country, two narratives' view of China. Despite different emphases, both sets' narratives of Chinese nationhood shared four interrelated elements: ethnicity (mainland China textbooks: 3.90%, Hong Kong textbooks: 6.71%), territory (21.90%, 5.55%), political conflicts between Han and non-Han ethnicities (24.11%, 39.42%), and cultural interactions between Han and non-Han ethnicities (50.08%, 48.32%) (see Table 1). Mainland China's construct of China was characterised mainly by constitutive territory with expressive ethnic inclusiveness for maintaining political unity, while Hong Kong's mainly featured China as a nation with constitutive ethnicity and expressive territory for ethnocultural identification.

The ethnocultural dimension of China: a han-centric vs a unified and multi-ethnic nation

The study's first finding is that both sets of textbooks sought to shape students' understanding of the ethnocultural component of China as a nation, an important indicator for examining the construct of China (Lu 2017), but differed over whether China was a Han-centric or unified multi-ethnic nation. Hong Kong textbooks narrated this dimension 35 times more than their mainland China counterparts (Table 1, Theme 1). Although both textbook sets stressed the Chinese nation (Hong Kong: 35 times, mainland China: 20) more than China and the Chinese people (23, 3), these subdimensions proportions were 1:1.52 in Hong Kong's textbooks and 1:6.67 in mainland China's. Further, despite commonly identifying Emperors Yan and Huang as China's ancestors (based on ancient writings), Hong Kong and mainland China textbooks narrated ethnic and cultural issues differently for different purposes, portraying China as Han-centric and unified multi-ethnic societies, respectively.

Hong Kong textbooks viewed Han ethnicity as China's primordial national boundary and China as a Han-culture-centric nation. The Hong Kong history textbook's (volume one) first lesson called China the 'Central Plains', home of the 'Huaxia ethnicity ... the predecessor of the current Han ethnicity' and the birthplace of the Chinese nation (Hong Kong-1, 9). Another lesson (about the Western Han Dynasty, 206BC-9AD) clarified that 'Chinese people were also called Han', referring to 'those from current Han ethnicity' (Hong Kong-2, 111).

Second, the Hong Kong narratives recounted that the Central Plain government used Han culture and governance to distinguish 'insiders' from 'outsiders'. Non-Han ethnicities who were 'assimilated by' or 'merged their culture into' Han culture and accepted Han governance became ethnic Han (Hong Kong-1, 172) and 'part of the Chinese nation' (Hong Kong-1 68); those who did not were considered 'outsiders' (Hong Kong-1, 43)

Table 1. Distribution of themes and categories of identified clauses in Hong Kong and mainland China textbooks.

Theme (and categories)	Clause in Hong Kong textbooks		Clause in mainland China textbooks		Difference in percentage between Hong Kong- and mainland China- textbooks (A–B)
	Frequency	Percentage (A)	Frequency	Percentage (B)	
1. Ethnicity-specific issues	58	6.71	23	3.90	2.80
China and Chinese people	23	2.66	3	0.51	2.15
Chinese nation	35	4.05	20	3.40	0.65
2. Territory-specific issues	48	5.55	129	21.90	–16.35
Chinese territory	17	1.97	16	2.72	–0.75
Areas non-Han groups inhabited	3	0.35	25	4.24	–3.90
Expansion of Chinese territory	18	2.08	0	0.00	2.08
Using current names to call places in old times	0	0.00	9	1.53	–1.53
Central government's governance over non-Han areas	10	1.16	79	13.41	–12.26
3. Military conflicts between Han and non-Han groups	341	39.42	142	24.11	15.31
Textbook's position on wars:					
Not showing any position	27	3.12	37	6.28	–3.16
Standing on the Han side	168	19.42	45	7.64	11.78
Standing on the non-Han side	0	0.00	9	1.53	–1.53
Hans' taking back central plains	39	4.51	10	1.70	2.81
Hans' resistance against the non-Han army	42	4.86	7	1.19	3.67
Non-Han army's atrocities	13	1.50	0	0	1.50
Criticising the Han regime's performance in the war	29	3.35	13	2.21	1.15
Other issues relating to war (e.g. Han and non-Han groups' agreement)	52	6.01	34	5.78	0.24
4. Non-military interactions between Han and non-Han groups (daily, between regimes, and domination)	418	48.32	295	50.08	–1.76
Textbook's position on ordinary interactions:					
Not showing any position	6	0.69	14	2.38	–1.68
Stressing learning of non-Han groups from Han	50	5.78	99	16.81	–11.03
Stressing learning of Han from non-Han groups	7	0.81	3	0.51	0.30
Stressing learning from each other	0	0.00	21	3.57	–3.57
Textbook's view on non-Han regime/leader					
Not showing any view	33	3.82	30	5.09	–1.28
Holding a positive view (e.g. praise)	57	6.59	16	2.72	3.87
Holding a negative view (e.g. criticism)	236	27.28	99	16.81	10.48
Total	865	100.00	589	100.00	

and a 'foreign threat' (Hong Kong-1, 72). Not-fully-Sinicised non-Han ethnicities that dominated China (i.e. Mongols (1271–1368) and Manchus (1644–1911)) were 'the host [of outsiders controlling] the Central Plains' (e.g. Hong Kong-3, 5).

Mainland China textbooks did not promote Han ethnicity as China's primordial national boundary. Instead, they transmitted the CPC's view of China as a 'unified multi-ethnic nation since antiquity' and emphasised that all ethnicities were part of the Chinese nation within its current territory. They diluted the link between 'Huaxia ethnicity' and 'Chinese nation' by not defining either and including all ethnic groups in the Chinese national family, emphasising that non-Han were members of 'our country' (e.g. mainland China-2, 34) and showing inclusiveness by using the contemporary Chinese term, 'ethnic minority' (e.g. mainland China-1, 59).

The geopolitical dimension of China: changing or unchanged borders?

This study combined Lu's (2017) two indicators (territoriality and governance) into a geopolitical component for narrating China as a nation because politically controlling and possessing a territory often go hand-in-hand. It found that both textbook sets provided dissimilar portrayals of China's territories and governance over non-Han ethnicities but weighted them differently, reflecting the two regions' different political goals. Hong Kong's narratives acknowledged that China's territory had changed over time, whereas mainland China depicted the PRC's current territories as inherited from antiquity.

While Hong Kong textbooks paid more attention to the ethnocultural dimension (mainland China: 23 mentions, Hong Kong: 58), mainland China textbooks gave more space to the geopolitical component (mainland China: 129, Hong Kong: 48) (Table 1, Theme 2). Mainland China's textbooks mentioned non-Han areas and their governance by Han 22 and 69 times more than Hong Kong's, respectively. Hong Kong narratives mentioned changes in China's territorial size 18 times and used historical placenames; mainland China textbooks never mentioned territorial changes and called historical places by their current names.

Specifically, Hong Kong's narratives did not see the PRC's current territory as China's primordial national boundary; instead, they depicted it as a nation with flexible geopolitical boundaries that changed by incorporating non-Han areas. They initially used whether non-Han accepted Han culture and governance as criteria for judging Chinese territory. For example, part of the Korean peninsula had been considered 'China's territory' during the Western Han Dynasty (Hong Kong-1, 108) but was excluded during the Tang Dynasty (618–907) after it rejected the Tang government's jurisdiction.

Hong Kong textbooks presented territorial changes in two ways. First, they acknowledged that China used wars and non-military means to take over non-Han areas (18 times, Table 1, Theme 2) and described how annexed areas were governed (10 times). Second, they compared 'territorial maps' for each Central Plains dynasty with China's current territory, drew 'territorial boundary' (*jiangjie*) lines between the dynasties and non-Han areas that rejected their governance, and compared unified dynasties' territories to show the changes in China's territory over time. For instance, the textbook noted that the Qing Dynasty's (1644–1911) territory was far larger than the Ming's (1368–1644) and 'laid the foundation for modern China's territory' (Hong Kong-3, 13).

Mainland China textbooks depicted the PRC's current territory as China's primordial national boundary and did not emphasise changes in territorial size in pre-modern

China. Instead, they reconstructed imperial territorial boundaries to match the PRC's current territory, ignoring former dynastic territories (e.g. the Korean peninsula) outside the PRC. They called the boundary lines between the then-Central Plains Dynasty and non-Han ethnicities within modern China 'regime/tribe boundaries' (*zhengquan/buzu bianjie*), and the line coming out of them 'current state boundaries' (*jin guojie*) (e.g. mainland China-2, 29).

Mainland China textbooks avoided some territorial changes by presenting only five dynastic maps. Only Tang, Yuan (1271–1368), and Qing Dynasty maps were called 'territory maps' because they included all non-Han areas currently within the PRC. The textbooks repeatedly claimed that all non-Han areas, especially politically sensitive areas (e.g. Xinjiang), belonged to or were in 'our country'. They referred to ancient places by their modern names and stressed that they had been within China's territories and under Han governance since antiquity. For example, mainland China textbooks first mentioned Xinjiang – a Uyghur-inhabited area in northwest China – when narrating the Western Han Dynasty's history, repeatedly stressing that the West Region/Xinjiang had been Chinese territory since antiquity:

The Western Han Dynasty reinforced [*jiaqiang*] governance over the West Region. In 60 BC, the Western Han Dynasty appointed a prefect to administer the West Region ... which marked the West Region formally belonged to the central government. The areas under Western Region Prefecture's jurisdiction included today's Xinjiang and the vast areas east and south of Baikal Lake. (Mainland China-1, 65)

The words 'reinforced', '60 BC', and 'marked' show that the Central Plains government had administered the Western Region, albeit informally, since antiquity. Specifying that the Western Region 'included today's Xinjiang' reinforces that claim. Similar narratives about Xinjiang appeared in the introduction to the Qing Dynasty's governance over peripheral areas (mainland China-2, 92).

Political conflicts between Han and non-Han ethnicities: internal or foreign wars?

The study's third finding concerns the textbook narratives on political conflicts (i.e. military confrontations between Han and non-Han). Hong Kong textbooks mentioned these wars twice as often as mainland China versions (341 times vs 142) (Table 1, Theme 3). Hong Kong textbooks sympathised with Han regimes' warfare and decried non-Han belligerence, while mainland China textbooks remained neutral, claiming all ethnicities accepted Han governance. In part, this could be because Hong Kong textbooks viewed interethnic wars as offensive-defensive confrontations between independent regimes for territorial control, while mainland China textbooks regarded them as civil wars.

Specifically, Hong Kong versions described non-Han wars against the Central Plain Dynasty as 'invasions' (*qinru*) or 'intrusions' (*qinrao*) designed to occupy 'a territory not their own' (e.g. Hong Kong-1,106). Mainland China textbooks used more moderate verbs like 'fought' (*douzhen*) and 'attack' (*jingong*) (mainland China-1,62) to dilute the territorial boundaries between Han and non-Han ethnicities. Hong Kong versions called Han-initiated wars 'conquest' (*zhengfu*) or 'expeditions' (*zhengfa*) to expand Han territories, while Mainland versions referred to them simply as 'wars'.

Hong Kong textbook narratives took positions on the wars more often than mainland China textbooks (195 times vs 91) (Table 1, Theme 3). Hong Kong narratives were one-sided; 86.15% (168 of 195) strongly supported the Han, while only 13.85% (mainly

concerning non-Han victories) were neutral. Mainland China narratives were either neutral (40.66% or 37 of 91) or supported Han (49.45%) over non-Han (9.89%).

These differences can also be seen in the textbook narratives on the results of interethnic wars. Hong Kong textbooks stressed expansion when the Han won and atrocities when they lost (13), a perspective rarely found in mainland China textbooks. For example, Hong Kong narratives emphasised that Hun's (a non-Han group) atrocities during years 311 and 316 'ended the Western Jin Dynasty (265-316)' (Hong Kong-1, 161). The mainland China narrative described the conflict in one sentence: 'The Hun destroyed the Western Jin' (mainland China-1, 82).

Moreover, the textbooks differed in narrating the Hans' defence against non-Han aggression. Hong Kong textbooks had far more clauses and provided more details about Han military attempts to reclaim Central Plains areas lost to non-Han (39 times) and resistance against non-Han aggression (42 times) than mainland China textbooks (10 and seven times, respectively) (Table 1, Theme 3). These wars included those leading to dynastic changes and power transitions from Han to non-Han ethnicities, such as Mongols establishing the Yuan Dynasty.

Hong Kong textbooks' accounts of these wars were more detailed. For example, in describing the transition from the Han-dominated Southern Song Dynasty (1127–1279) to the Mongol-led Yuan Dynasty, Hong Kong textbooks placed the war in a passage about the Southern Song Dynasty's demise, while mainland China textbooks put it in a passage about the Yuan Dynasty's founding. Moreover, the Hong Kong narrative saw them as wars between different regimes, while the mainland China version portrayed them as internal conflicts between two ethnic groups from the same 'family'. Hong Kong textbooks used four full pages (with maps) to portray how four loyal Han officials – Zhang Shijie (died in 1279), Lu Xiufu (1238–1279), Wen Tianxiang (1236–1283), Lv Wenhua (died in 1298) – resisted the Mongol invasion, despite their eventual failure (Hong Kong-2, 116–119). In contrast, the mainland China narrative focused more on the Mongols' unification of China than the Hans' loss of ruling power, using one sentence in the main text to relate that Wen Tianxiang and Lv Wenhuan fought the Mongol army (mainland China-2, 49). Paradoxically, the CPC has, since the 1950s, recognised and promoted Wen Tianxiang as a national hero for resisting the Mongols.

Cultural interactions between Han and non-Han ethnicities: equal or unequal status?

The study's fourth finding concerns interethnic cultural interactions (the interethnic relations and cultural status of ethnic groups), as Lu (2017) suggested. This was the most narrated of the four components in both mainland China (50.08%) and Hong Kong (48.32%) textbooks (Table 1, Theme 4). However, Hong Kong textbooks offered more narratives on these interactions (418) than mainland China versions (295). Both emphasised Han cultural and political superiority but differed in extent and expression.

Both textbook sets presented a strong sense of Han superiority, but mainland China textbooks were more cautious about provoking interethnic conflicts. While mainland China textbooks offered over twice as many narratives (137) as Hong Kong versions (63), the proportions of neutral narratives on Han/non-Han cultural interactions were

similar in mainland China (10.22% or 14 of 137) and Hong Kong textbooks (9.52% or 6 of 63) (Table 1, Theme 4). Both regions' narratives stressed that non-Han ethnicities learnt from the Han (Hong Kong, 79.37%; mainland China, 72.26%). Mainland China textbooks were more willing to mention learning from each other (15.33%) but less willing to mention the Han learning from non-Han (2.19%) than Hong Kong textbooks (0 and 11.11%, respectively).

Both regions' textbooks promoted Han cultural superiority at the societal level. For example, Hong Kong textbooks repeatedly highlighted how the Han 'assimilated' and 'Sinicised' non-Han (e.g. Hong Kong-1, 172–173). When mutual learning was narrated, mainland China textbooks stressed that non-Han learnt important things (e.g. Chinese language), while the Han learnt relatively trivial ones (e.g. ethnic music and food) (mainland China-1, 88), and strategically placed the narratives of non-Han ethnicities' learning first.

To different extents, mainland China and Hong Kong textbooks stressed non-Han regimes'/leaders' Sinification efforts in establishing state structures, making civil servants and military policies, developing their economy, and creating characters. Both stressed that the non-Han Xianbei ethnicity's reforms during the Northern and Southern Dynasties (386–589) were modelled on Han policies and accelerated non-Han ethnicities' Sinification (Hong Kong-1, 172–173 and mainland China-1, 88). However, Hong Kong textbooks mentioned reforms omitted from mainland China textbooks, such as replacing Xianbei policies and laws with Han versions, adopting a land equalisation policy, and transforming Xianbei's nomadism to agriculturalism (Hong Kong-1, 173).

Both textbook sets' Han-centric perspectives were reflected in their views on non-Han regimes or leaders who ruled China. Hong Kong textbooks had over twice as many narratives on non-Han regimes/leaders (326 vs 145) (Table 1, Theme 4), and more were negative (72.39% vs 68.28%). For example, the third Hong Kong history textbook volume asserted that the Manchu-dominated Qing Dynasty lasted longer than the Mongol-controlled Yuan Dynasty because it was 'far more Sinicised', '[understood] Han cultural superiority', and '[incorporated] Han culture in governing' (Hong Kong-1, 14).

Hong Kong textbooks were less tolerant of and more often critical of non-Han regimes/leaders, dedicating significant space to criticising the Yuan (four pages) and Qing Dynasties' (three pages) cruel policies toward Han groups, including suppressing and exploiting Han, destroying their culture, and separating them from other ethnicities (Hong Kong-2, 128–131; Hong Kong-3, 14–16). The second history textbook volume explicitly attributed the Yuan Dynasty's Mongol leaders' poor governance to their 'lack of education and political wisdom and adoption of a backward, nomadic approach to governing the Han' (Hong Kong-2, 128).

Mainland China textbooks were more tolerant of non-Han cultures, less explicitly referencing Han superiority and commenting on non-Han regimes/leaders. Aside from describing Han production instruments and techniques as 'advanced' (mainland China-1, 84; mainland China-2, 33), mainland China textbooks generally asserted Han superiority implicitly. For example, one mainland China passage mentioned that during the Southern and Northern Dynasties (420–589), a Xianbei leader increased his regime's strength by promoting Sinicisation reforms (mainland China-1, 84–88). Mainland China textbooks portrayed the Han/non-Han interethnic relationship as peaceful to avoid fanning Han students' resentment of ethnic minorities. The second mainland China history textbook

volume criticised the Mongol-led Yuan Dynasty's policy of dividing people into four ethnic hierarchies, but only in the supplementary readings, which said that 'people in different ethnic hierarchies were treated differently in politics, economy, and law' (mainland China-2, 53).

Discussion and conclusion: convergence or divergence of Chinese history education in mainland China and Hong Kong?

Guided by Lu's (2017) framework, this study has found four interrelated themes for narrating pre-1912 China as a nation in mainland China's and Hong Kong's Chinese textbooks under the 'one country, two systems' principle: China's ethnic and territory dimensions, interethnic political conflicts, and cultural interactions. However, these themes diverged more than converged in the regions' Chinese history education. The Chinese textbooks' construction of China as a nation differed in emphasis and extent, resulting in 'one country, two narratives.' Mainland China's construct was characterised more by constitutive territory with expressive ethnicity for political harmony, and Hong Kong's mainly by constitutive ethnicity and expressive territory for ethnocultural identification and thus highlight more on interethnic conflicts and Han's superiority.

Unlike national identity studies focusing on ethnic issues in school history curricula (Latif 2019; Lin and Jackson 2019; Takeda and Williams 2008; Won and Huntington 2021; Yan and Vickers 2019; 2024), this study has demonstrated the importance of including territorial narratives and demonstrated that ethnicity and territory could be contingently manipulated as national primordial boundaries (Brubaker 1996; Lu 2017). Moreover, while confirming that both regions' Chinese history textbooks promote Han superiority (Lin and Jackson 2019; Yan and Vickers 2019; 2024), the study has further shown that Hong Kong's promotion is far more explicit.

To better explain these findings and how they arose in the specific context of 'one country, two systems', the study proposes understanding (a) history education as a contextualised, socio-political construction of the past to foster national identity reflecting the dominant actors' negotiation and compromise and (b) textbooks as a major socio-political instrument for narrating and disseminating the construction. For different socio-political ends, dominant actors in different political/social systems, even within one country, strategically select, interpret, and manipulate the past to construct official nation narratives that reflect their goals and interests and disseminate them via textbooks, a politico-cultural device.

This study contributes to understanding the debates on constructing a nation and fostering national identity through history education in three major ways. First, it found that the indicators distinguishing the ethnic and territorial patterns that emerged in this study are more complex than Lu's (2017) analysis framework and supplement it in three ways. The first modifies some of his indicators to form broader themes, i.e. (1) combining antagonistic relations in the interethnic relations indicator with interethnic political conflicts to form the theme of political conflicts and (2) combining the peaceful relations in the interethnic relations indicator with cultural status to form the theme of interethnic cultural interactions. The second re-defines and re-categorises Lu's indicators of political governance over peripheral areas and cultural status. Per Lu's criteria, mainland China and Hong Kong textbooks were expected to adopt similar patterns in narrating these two items;

however, they narrated the indicators differently, with different patterns and discourses. The third enriches Lu's indicators by adding new indicators of the Han governments' efforts at defending their land and the tensions in interethnic military interactions.

Second, the 'one country, two narratives' view of China as a nation in the textbooks reveals a contextualised, socio-political exercise of nation construction, reflecting different interactions between government and textbook editors/writers in different contexts for different purposes. Mainland China textbooks promote the CPC-prescribed 'unified multi-ethnic nation' to maintain political unity and territorial integrity (Xu 2021b). The CPC, the sole prescriber of China's construction and principal shaper of history education and textbooks (Xu 2018), can select and monitor expert textbook writers to voice and legitimise the Party-prescribed nation (Xu 2021b). The Hong Kong government, having some local autonomy, allows its Chinese textbooks' continued reinterpretation of China as a Han-centric ethnocultural nation (Vickers, Kan, and Morris 2003), collaborating with curriculum developers and textbook writers who identify with Chinese culture to adapt the subject to political and social contexts (Kan 2007). The reinterpretation could help maintain China's attractiveness to Hong Kong Han – distant from China and having a strong sense of local identity – and suit Hong Kong's context as an international city (Lo 2007).

Third, both textbook sets confront ambiguities in constructing China as a nation. Despite trying to show China's inclusiveness, Mainland China textbooks vacillate between promoting China as a 'united multi-ethnic nation' and highlighting Han culture, possibly because they have been more Han-centric and promoted non-Han assimilation (Yan and Vickers 2024). Hong Kong's Han-centric Chinese textbooks were not culturally inclusive and challenged non-Han Chinese and international students (Lin and Jackson 2019). Moreover, both textbook sets reflect the tensions between the two notions of China as a nation. While promoting China as a multi-ethnic nation, mainland China textbooks have, since the 1980s, introduced academic works written by overseas cultural conservationists (e.g. Hsu Cho-Yun, Qian Mu) to foster students' identity with traditional Han-centric Chinese culture and state-centric governance (Xu 2018). While promoting the ethnocultural notion of China, Hong Kong textbooks have focused more on territorial integrity, particularly after 2020, when Beijing asked Hong Kong to defend China's national and territorial security (Vickers 2024; Vickers and Morris 2022). These ambiguities and tensions increase teaching and learning difficulties and create dilemmas for teachers in handling the different purposes of history education. Encouraging students to inquire about and evaluate the historical past in different versions of textbooks and materials may help construct a version of the nation that is more acceptable to them.

Despite its contributions, the study has limitations that could be addressed by future research. First, it explored how China was constructed as a nation in mainland China and Hong Kong history textbooks. More research on both societies is needed to understand how the nation is constructed in other subjects, such as Chinese language and civic-education-related subjects. Second, the study focused on how the two regions' Chinese history textbooks were used in the late 2010s and 2020; future projects could pay more attention to how they construct China since the recent curricula revisions and, in particular, the central government's unilateral enactment of the *National Security Law for Hong Kong* in 2020 (Vickers 2024; Vickers and Morris 2022). Third, the study focused

on what Chinese history textbooks intended to teach in schools – the official version of the nation constructed by dominant interest groups in mainland China and Hong Kong. Future research could explore how narratives of China are taught and learned in history classes and how and why teachers and students reinterpret and assess official versions of China constructed in mainland China and Hong Kong.

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Notes on Contributor

Shuqin Xu is an associate professor of Research Centre for Public Administration and School of Government at Sun Yat-Sen University. Her main research areas include politics in education, educational policy and governance, and citizenship education.

ORCID

Shuqin Xu  <http://orcid.org/0000-0003-1648-9042>

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